

BODY DECODE • FOUR PATTERNS

The Fat Map

Where your body stores fat narrows it down. What comes with it is what decides.

First, what the Fat Map actually is.

Your body does not store fat randomly. Where it puts it, and what else changes at the same time, depends on which hormone is driving it.

The Fat Map is how we read that.

It is not a diagnosis and it is not a body type. Nobody is a “pear” or an “apple” for life. It is a way of narrowing down which of **four hormones** is most likely behind what your body is doing right now, so that what you do about it is aimed at the right thing.

Four hormones. Four different places it shows up. Four completely different fixes.

Why it is worth ten minutes of your time. The four fixes are not interchangeable. The exact advice that sorts one of these out will make two of the others worse. Not “less effective”. Worse. So getting the aim right matters more than trying harder does.

The short version, if you read nothing else

HORMONE	WHERE IT SITS	WHAT TELLS YOU IT IS THIS ONE
Cortisol	Front of the stomach, waist	Middle up while arms and legs get thinner
Insulin	Back, lower back, love handles	3pm crash, cravings after dinner
Oestrogen (women)	Hips and thighs, later the middle	Whether it moved there, and which way
Testosterone (men)	Nowhere. It is a body-shape change	Muscle and drive dropping

Read the middle column on its own. Three of the four say roughly “your middle”, which is exactly why where it sits is not enough.

Now read the last column. They come apart straight away.

The rest of this guide takes each one properly, with a picture of where it shows up and one thing worth trying this week.

Now the bit that trips everyone up.

“Belly fat means stress.” You have heard that a hundred times. It is wrong about as often as it is right.

Here is the problem with it.

Four hormones can drive fat storage. Three of them push it to your middle.

So if you are carrying it around the middle, that tells you almost nothing on its own. You have narrowed it down to three out of four. That is not a read. That is a coin toss with extra steps.

What actually separates them is the **thing that shows up alongside it**. Where the fat sits narrows it down. What comes with it is what decides.

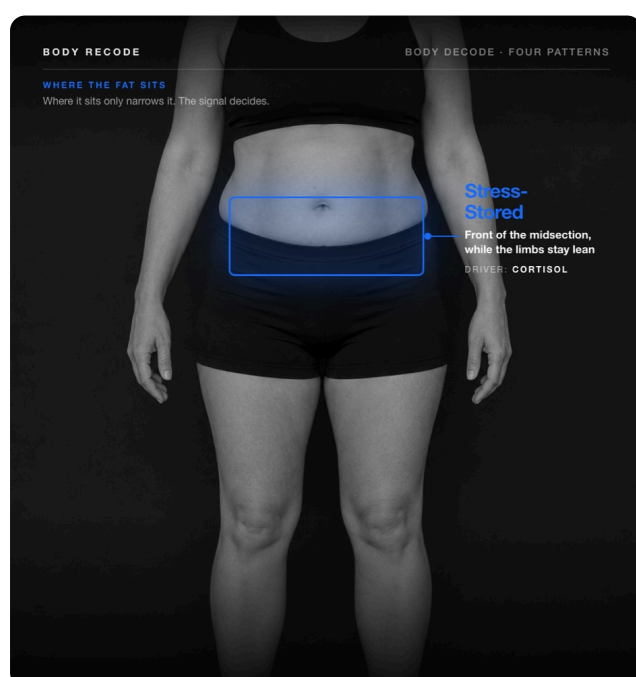
So the rest of this guide is the four of them, one at a time. Where each one puts it, and the single signal that tells you it is that one rather than the other three.

About the pictures. Only two of the four are actually a place on your body. One shows up on your back. The fourth is not a place at all, so there is nothing to draw. Each one is shown on the body it can happen to.

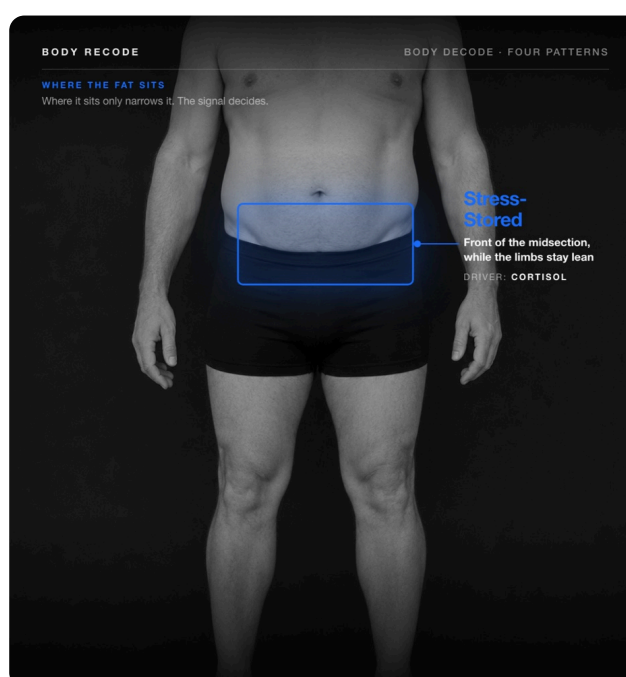
1 Cortisol · the stress one

WHERE IT SHOWS UP

Front of your stomach. Your waist.



Front of the stomach, arms and legs staying lean



Same thing on a male body

THE SIGNAL THAT DECIDES IT

Your middle is getting bigger while your arms and legs are getting thinner.

That combination is the giveaway. Not the belly on its own. The belly *plus* the limbs going the other way.

No other hormone does that.

Why it goes there. Belly fat has far more of the docking points that cortisol plugs into than the fat on your arms and legs does. So when stress is running high, that is where your body puts it.

What helps: taking pressure off. Less training load, and protecting your sleep.

What makes it worse: training harder and eating less. Your body is already in defence mode. Push harder and it just holds on tighter.

TRY THIS WEEK

Take one hard session out of this week and put a walk in its place.

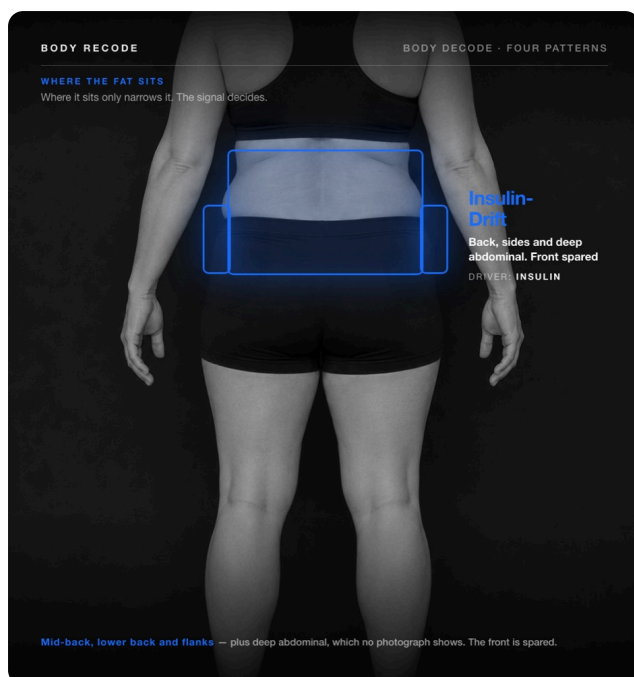
That is it. Do not change your food. If your body is in defence mode, removing a stressor is the only thing that gets you anywhere, and this is the cheapest one to remove.

If a week of that leaves you feeling better rather than guilty, that is information.

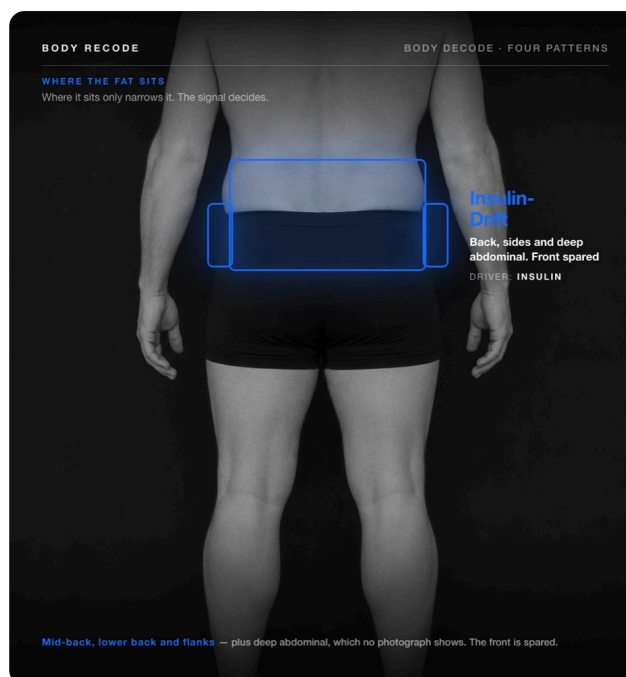
2**Insulin • the food-timing one****WHERE IT SHOWS UP**

Your back and your sides. Mid-back, lower back, the love handles. Your waist feels firm and full rather than soft.

The front of your stomach can look relatively flat.



Mid-back, lower back and sides. The front is spared



Same thing on a male body

These are the only two pictures here taken from behind. That is the whole point. Everyone checks the front in the mirror. This one shows up where you cannot see it.

THE SIGNAL THAT DECIDES IT

A hard crash in the afternoon, and cravings that hit after dinner.

Front versus back is what separates this from stress. If the fat is on your back and your energy falls off a cliff around 3pm, you are looking at insulin, not cortisol.

One thing worth clearing up. Going soft all over is **not** an insulin sign. People get told that constantly and it is not true. General softness sits in a completely different layer of fat. If your honest answer is “it is fairly even, I could not pick one spot”, this is not your pattern.

What helps: *when you eat, and what you eat it with.* Carbs alongside protein at lunch land very differently to carbs on their own at 9pm.

What makes it worse: not much, honestly, and that is the trap. This is the one pattern where normal advice half works. So you get a bit of movement, assume you are on the right track, and then stall.

TRY THIS WEEK

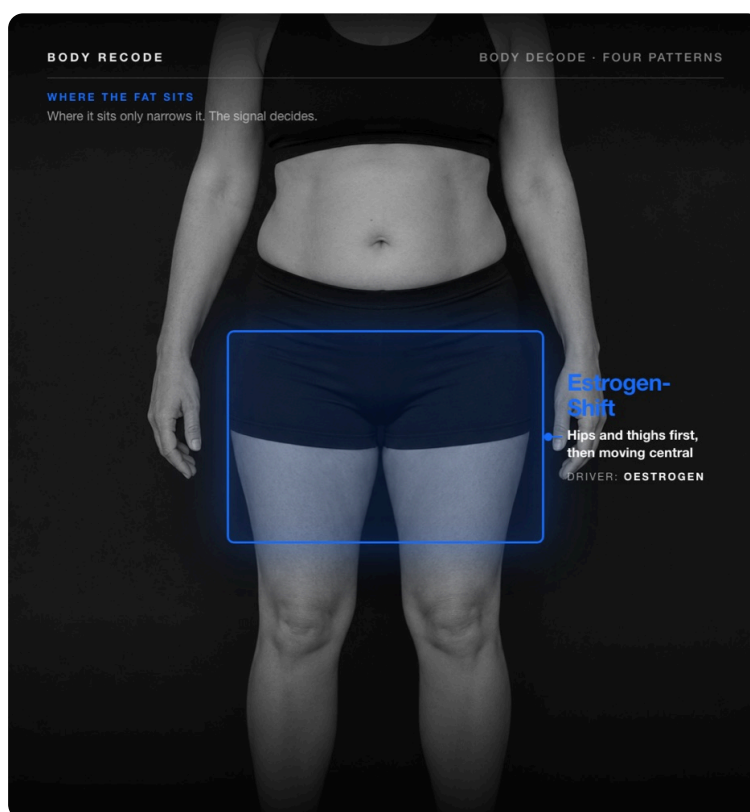
Walk for ten to fifteen minutes after your biggest meal of the day.

Not a workout. A walk. Do it for a week and pay attention to the afternoon, because on this pattern that small thing tends to change how you feel far more than it has any right to.

If it makes an obvious difference, that is a clue about which pattern you are in.

3**Oestrogen · the one that changes on you · women**

This one has **two completely different stages**, and they need opposite things. That is why it gets missed more than any of the others.



Stage one. Hips, bum and outer thighs

STAGE ONE, WHILE YOUR CYCLE IS REGULAR

It sits on your hips, bum and outer thighs. Like the picture above.

STAGE TWO, AS OESTROGEN DROPS AWAY

That same fat starts moving to your middle, and you start losing muscle at the same time. This is perimenopause and beyond.

There is no picture for stage two, on purpose. On a body it looks exactly like the stress one at the start of this guide, and no photograph will ever separate them.

One question does, though. Did it arrive at your middle, or has your middle always been where you carried it? Oestrogen arrives there, from your hips. Cortisol was central from the start. If your honest answer is “it has always been my middle”, this is not your pattern, and you should be reading the cortisol one instead.

THE SIGNAL THAT DECIDES IT

Whether it moved, and which way it went.

Not where it sits today. Not your age, and not your cycle either, though both are part of the picture.

One question does the work: **has where you store it changed over the last few years?** If it used to be your hips and thighs and it is heading for your middle, that movement is the signal, and it matters more than where it ends up.

What helps: eating consistently. Properly, and regularly.

What makes it worse: cutting back. Your body reads that as “food is scarce” and holds on harder. The harder you diet, the tighter the grip.

TRY THIS WEEK

For one week, do not cut anything. Add a proper breakfast with protein in it.

This feels like the wrong direction, and that is exactly why it is worth trying. If your body has been reading your day as a shortage, the fix is not a smaller day.

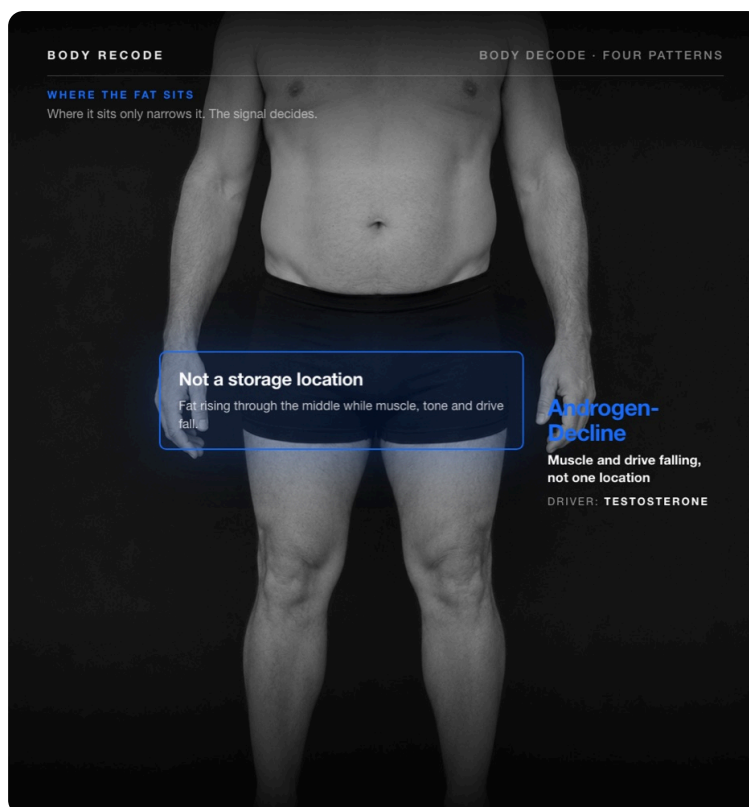
One week is not going to undo anything. It will tell you something.

4

Testosterone · the one that is not a place · men

WHERE IT SHOWS UP

Nowhere specific. That is the point.



Nothing is marked, because there is nothing to mark

Your middle fills out. At the same time your muscle goes, your strength drops, and your drive and recovery go with it. Notice the picture has nothing highlighted on it. There is nothing to highlight, and that is the read.

THE SIGNAL THAT DECIDES IT

The muscle disappearing, not the fat arriving.

Putting on fat by itself does not mean anything here. Fat going up *while muscle and drive go down* does.

Why it feeds itself. Fat tissue converts testosterone into oestrogen. So more fat means less testosterone, which means more fat. Your arms look softer because you are losing muscle, not because you are gaining fat there.

What helps: protecting your muscle first, before anything else.

What makes it worse: hard dieting. It costs you the muscle you were trying to keep, which speeds the whole thing up.

TRY THIS WEEK

Keep two or three proper resistance sessions in the week, and stop cutting food to get there.

Muscle is the thing holding this pattern together. If you are choosing between a harder diet and keeping your strength work, keep the strength work every time.

Protein at every meal helps more here than any further cut will.

If none of this quite fits you, that is a real answer. Not a fail. Plenty of bodies do not sort neatly by where they store fat, and a body that is working well will not fit any of these. Forcing yourself into the closest-looking box is exactly how people end up fixing a problem they do not have.

Remember it can change. These are not fixed types. What your body is doing now is not what it will be doing after the thing driving it shifts. Anyone telling you your permanent type from a photo is selling you something.

WANT TO KNOW WHICH ONE IS ACTUALLY YOURS?

The free **14-Day Body Decode Challenge** asks you some questions on day one, checks eight things against your own starting point on day seven, and tells you your pattern on day fourteen. Which one is running yours, and what to do about that specific one.

Free. Nothing to pay to get your read.

bodyrecode.au/challenge